



Indians in ISL since 2014



No. of Indian Golden Boot winners:

0

No. of Indians in the top 10 goalscorers

2

No. of Indians in the top 10 assist providers

3

No. of Indian head coaches in ISL

2

Money matters: Lalengmawia Ralte (centre) and Anirudh Thapa (left) are among the big-money signings at Mohun Bagan. FSDL

problem of plenty, with several players being lost in the shuffle. The Kolkata outfit has an array of Indian talent, which includes Anirudh Thapa, Sahal Abdul Samad, Lalengmawia Ralte, Liston Colaco, Manvir Singh, Ashique Kuruniyan and Deepak Tangri.

Thapa and Samad — two talented attacking midfielders, who made big-money moves to Bagan in the summer of 2023 — have enjoyed significant upheaval in their trophy haul and wages.

But this season, on the pitch, they have had to take a back seat since the arrival of another exciting midfield talent, Ralte. In the 2023–24 campaign, Thapa and Samad averaged 64.86 and 69.53 minutes per 90, but in the recently concluded season, the playing time has

dropped to 55.38 and 42.94 respectively.

While the ISL has undoubtedly raised the ceiling among the Indian players, there have also been accusations of complacency, most notably raised by the national team coach, Manolo Marquez. “My feeling is that Indian players are very comfortable,” the Spaniard pointed out. “Life is so good for them in the ISL that it is difficult for them to try and go abroad.”

Last season, Ralte was reportedly registered outside the new salary cap regulations, while Thapa and Samad are also among the best-paid Indian players in the league.

The preference to look abroad also extends to coaching roles, with Indians often being overlooked.

Marquez, in his first press conference after his appointment, said, “In the future, the national team coach has to be Indian. An Indian coach will know better how the country works and the people in every part of India.”